

Narrative Crossroads: The Interlopers

A character analysis framework for exploring key decisions and motivations

Overview

This module adapts the Narrative Crossroads framework for analyzing Saki’s “The Interlopers.” Students write in character as either Ulrich von Gradwitz or Georg Znaeym at pivotal moments in the story, exploring how generational hatred and unexpected circumstances affect character development.

Setting Context

- **Time Period:** Early 20th century
- **Location:** Forested region in the Carpathian Mountains of Eastern Europe
- **Social Context:** Landed gentry, inherited feuds, territorial disputes
- **Atmosphere:** Hostile, ominous, wild, transitional

Character Options

Choose, or roll a die.

Roll	Character	What they want	What they fear
1–3	Ulrich von Gradwitz	The disputed forest, and the feud settled in his favour	Dying with the quarrel unfinished
4–6	Georg Znaeym	What he believes his family is owed	Being made to look weak by conceding

Threshold Moments

Choose, or roll a die. Everyone works the same moment.

Roll	Threshold Moment	Why it is a threshold
1–2	Before the storm — patrolling the forest	Deciding whether to pursue the enemy or wait; and Confronting the rival when spotted
3–4	Trapped under the fallen beech tree	Initial reaction to shared predicament; and Deciding whether to offer reconciliation
5–6	After reconciliation, before wolves arrive	Planning for rescue; and Reflecting on the new alliance

The Three Lenses

Everyone works from the same character at the same threshold moment. Each student takes one lens — pick, or roll a die so the room spreads across all three. The die only chooses the way in; nothing is rolled against a character, and there is nothing to succeed or fail at.

Roll	Lens	What it asks at this moment
1–2	Confrontation	A clash. What are you up against, and what does facing it cost?
3–4	Comprehension	A realization. What do you understand now that you didn't a moment ago?
5–6	Connection	The bonds. Who is this really about, and what do you owe them?

Then write a few sentences in the character's voice, at that moment, showing one thing from the character's wants or fears. The writing is the play.

Thematic Elements

- The destructive nature of inherited hatred
 - Man versus nature
 - Irony of fate
 - Reconciliation and redemption
 - The meaninglessness of human feuds against natural forces
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Implementation Guide

Classroom Setup (45–60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the round and distribute cards
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students choose a character, or roll a die for one
3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** The teacher frames one moment for the whole room
4. **Evidence (10 min):** Students fill the Character Frame — what this character wants and fears, with a line or page number
5. **Take a lens and write (15–20 min):** Students take a lens and write in character
6. **Harvest (10–15 min):** Read several aloud, at least one per lens, then ask which reading the text supports

Materials Needed

- A die per table, if you want to assign lenses by chance rather than choice. It is optional; students can simply pick.
 - Character Frame cards
 - Copy of the text
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Assessment Options

- **Character Journal:** Students submit written responses from the character's perspective
 - **Audio Character Study:** Students record their written response, read aloud in character
 - **Comparative Analysis:** Students analyze how the feud shapes each character's worldview
 - **Alternate Ending:** Students explore what might have happened without the wolves' arrival
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ELA Standards Alignment

- **RL.9-10.2** — Determine a theme and analyze in detail its development over the course of the text
 - **RL.9-10.3** — Analyze how complex characters develop, interact with other characters, and advance the plot
 - **W.9-10.3** — Write narratives with well-structured event sequences
 - **SL.9-10.1** — Initiate and participate effectively in collaborative discussions
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Sample Response

Character: Georg Znaeym

Threshold Moment: Trapped under the fallen beech tree — the moment when Georg and Ulrich are pinned by the tree, forced into proximity.

Lens: Connection

What they wrote:

When Ulrich strains to offer you his wine flask, your immediate reaction is suspicion and resentment. Despite your shared predicament, decades of hatred cannot be so easily set aside. 'So you would like to drink with me, Herr von Gradwitz?' you say with bitter mockery. 'Why don't we toast to the death of my hunting rights, or to the infamous lawsuit that stole this land from my family?' The words escape your lips before you can consider any opportunity for reconciliation. You see something change in Ulrich's eyes—perhaps disappointment, perhaps a rekindling of his own hatred. The moment of potential connection passes, though you wonder if you've made a tactical error. As the night deepens and the cold intensifies, your stubborn refusal begins to feel hollow in the face of your shared fate.

Version 3

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